

Time for a Linux makeover

If you're into tinkering and own an Android phone, you'll no doubt have messed with the device. Perhaps, you've put on a custom ROM coupled with a custom kernel with a non-OEM launcher and icon pack to give it a little zing. Customising your personal devices brings a level of satisfaction like no other. Most of us have applied some level of customisation to our devices. Even putting on a custom wallpaper and messing around with widgets also counts as customisation, but you'd want to go beyond wallpapers. That's when you explore different ROMs and then explore how deep the rabbit hole goes.

A decade ago, you'd most likely have customised your desktop first before even thinking of messing around with your smartphone. On the PC, you could change the BIOS logo, the start up logo, your lockscreen style and a lot more. That's because back in the days, the desktop was very unappealing to look at. And that's very much true to this day. And with each newer version of Windows, it's becoming more and more convoluted to play around with these customisations. Thankfully, there's a better OS – Linux.

With Linux, there are plenty of distros to choose from and each distro comes with its own flavour of customisations. Given the way Linux is built, it's very easy to type in a few commands and swap out the UI completely. Think of it like switching to a new launcher on your Android phone. On Linux, the launcher is called a Desktop Environment. And you can switch between 10s of different Desktop Environments. In this FastTrack, we've picked nine of the most popular Desktop Environments and compared